

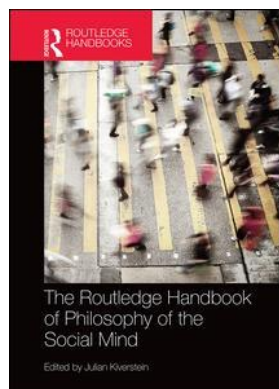
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SOCIAL ROLES AND
REIFICATION¹*Ron Mallon*

Stand in a crowded urban center, and you can see an extraordinarily diverse, amazingly complex social world that is structured in part by widespread understandings about the properties, functions, rights, privileges, duties, obligations, and restraints of certain groups of people in certain domains – structured in part by *social roles*.

One source of such roles is our institutions. Our institutions are full of social roles like teacher, lawyer, doctor, member of Congress, Starbucks barista, licensed pipefitter, and fully-paid-up member of the American Philosophical Association, and these social roles structure permissions, restrictions, expectations, and behaviors in ways that facilitate coordination and, sometimes, cooperation. When we look across the crowd, we see many conspicuous markers of such social role status, including uniforms and badges that allow us to fix expectations for interpersonal regulation, coordination, and cooperation.

But there is also a long *social constructionist* tradition that insists upon the importance of another type of social role: social roles like *being a man or a woman; homosexual or straight; Asian, black, or white; angry or sad*. This second group of roles differs from institutional roles in that these categories are widely understood to be *natural kinds* of person – kinds that exist or have their character independently of our classificatory practices, perhaps because they are some sort of biological kind. Again, when we look out on the street, we see many indicators of membership in these roles. For sex and race, conspicuous features of the body are often taken to be indicators of kind membership. In some cases, clothing or other artifacts may indicate membership as well.

In the face of the temptation to treat such kinds as natural, social constructionists provocatively insist that these kinds are actually some sort of *social kind* – a product of our culture, decisions, or social practices. Social constructionists think that these kinds exist because of our (historical and current) practices of thinking of them and treating them as different. In effect, they attempt to explain kind differences not by appeal to nature, but by appeal to social roles. Borrowing some terminology from Paul Griffiths (1997), we can call the transparent, institutional sort of social role an *overt* role or construction, and the latter, putatively natural but actually social kind, a *covert* role or construction.

Examples of covert constructionist claims about human kinds are not hard to find in the contemporary humanities and social sciences. Begin with race. The philosopher Paul Taylor writes that,

White supremacist societies created the Races they thought they were discovering, and the ongoing political developments in these societies continued to re-create

them. . . . All of this is to say: our Western races are social constructs. They are things that we humans create in the transactions that define social life.

(2013, 179)

Michael Omi and Howard Winant similarly claim:

The effort must be made to understand race as an unstable and “decentered” complex of social meanings constantly being transformed by political struggle. . . . The concept of race continues to play a fundamental role in structuring and representing the social world. The task for theory is to explain this situation. It is to avoid both the utopian framework which sees race as an illusion we can somehow “get beyond,” and also the essentialist formulation which sees race as something objective and fixed, a biological datum. Thus we should think of race as an element of social structure . . .

(1994, 55)

This core idea, that races are products of human sociocultural activity, but are widely believed to be natural, is widespread among humanistic racial theorists.

Claims of the construction of gender kinds are also ubiquitous. For example, Catherine McKinnon claims of gender that:

Gender has no basis in anything other than the social reality its hegemony constructs. Gender is what gender means. The process that gives sexuality its male supremacist meaning is the same process through which gender inequality becomes socially real.

(1987, 173)

The suggestion is, again, that gender differences are products of our cultural practices of assigning meanings to bodies and differentially treating them, resulting in differences that are mistakenly interpreted as natural.

Another influential example is Michel Foucault’s (1978) claim that as ideas or concepts of sexuality shifted in nineteenth-century Europe, they became more committed to the idea that sexual behavior was indicative of importantly different, underlying kinds of people. And Foucault believes these new understandings actually caused homosexuality to come to exist (not just the label, the idea, or the concept, but the kind itself).

Such claims raise many questions; here I focus upon the question of what covertly constructed kinds are. Suppose that we allow that covert constructionists are correct that some putatively natural human kinds are actually a production of our social and conceptual activities, that they are some sort of social role. What explains their apparent existence and sustains their causal power over time?

Notice that the natural kind theorist answers these questions by appealing to the natural kind; the natural kind gender theorist, for example, answers these questions by appeal to biological sex. In contrast, the social constructionist wants to appeal to widespread understandings of gender and the social practices that they structure to explain gender kinds. But how shall we understand these?

Because they are produced in some way by our social and conceptual activities, it is tempting to understand covert social roles by analogy with overt institutional roles. In both cases, our social and cultural practices serve to differentiate social role members from others, creating real-world effects. And, in both cases, if we could intervene upon these representational practices, we could thereby alter their consequences.

Despite these similarities, covert, socially constructed human categories are a different kind of kind than institutional categories. The mechanism that stabilizes and sustains these kinds over time is different (Mallon in press). Appreciating this difference is crucial to appreciating the different sorts of ways our social world acquires its structure and to understanding how we might go about transforming or eliminating them.

Here is how I proceed. In the first section, I briefly articulate this understanding of covert constructionist explanations as appealing to social roles. I then consider the possibility of interpreting such constructed roles as products of overt construction. But, I go on to argue, overt and covert constructions are different kinds of kinds. I conclude by connecting the discussion to concerns with social change.

Social roles

I am interpreting the social constructionist as understanding social kinds as a sort of social role (cf. Griffiths 1997; Mallon 2003, Mallon and Kelly 2012, Mallon 2016). As I use the term, a social role is created when a kind representation becomes widespread, common knowledge in a community. A social role in this sense exists in a community when ideas about the membership conditions for the role, about the permissions, duties, and other norms attaching to role members, and about role-typical properties, become something everyone in a community knows, knows that every knows, and so on.²

For covert social roles, these representations represent kind membership or kind typical properties as “natural” facts. In many cases, such facts may be explained as the result of biological or endogenous features of kind members, but it could also include extrinsic causes like “divine will”. The important feature of this sense of “natural” is that the existence and character of the kind is understood as given and as independent of human choices either in the past or at present.

Such representations may also include stereotypes or other sorts of representations that distinguish category members. The causal power of the resulting kinds is then explained by appeal to the causal effects of the representations upon behavior with regard to, toward, and by kind members. Such causal effects of representations may occur via a range of causal pathways, including both actions and policies guided by explicit beliefs about kind members (e.g. racist or sexist beliefs) and also pathways in which representations influence individual behavior automatically and perhaps unconsciously in ways that can be at odds with background beliefs or intentions (cf. Bargh and Chartrand 1999; Gendler 2008; Huebner 2009; Mallon in press).

(Actual or possible) features of the constructed kinds may then be understood or explained by considering the meaning of the kind representations as well as the mechanisms by which those representations influence behavior by and towards kind members. This is an elaboration of the covert constructionist position, going beyond what constructionists typically say. Still, something like this elaboration seems necessary in order for the sorts of claims considered above (and many others in the humanities and social sciences) to be true. It allows us to understand provocative claims like Foucault’s insistence that homosexuality first came to exist in the nineteenth century as a claim about a certain kind representation coming to be widespread in a way that structured social life.

On such a picture, the social constructionist about a human kind appeals to the social role – the widespread representation and its systematic causal effects on the social environment and on kind members – in explanation of the existence or features of a category in a way that parallels the natural kind theorists’ appeal to underlying natural difference. *Both* the constructionist and the natural kind theorist hold that the underlying category is a real thing, but they

disagree about the character or nature of that thing. What remains for both of them to provide is a further specification of the underlying kinds or mechanisms, and an account of how, exactly, these explain whatever differences or regularities are in question.

Appealing to overt kinds

But how should we understand the mechanism or mechanisms that sustain covertly constructed social roles and make them causally powerful? One promising suggestion is that we should understand socially constructed covert kinds in the same way we understand socially constructed *overt* kinds, like social institutions. As I noted at the outset, there are many institutional social roles, roles like *being a licensed driver*, or *being the President of the United States*, for which the differential features of the persons in the roles apparently stem from some set of social institutions and conventions.

Many philosophers hint at this strategy by using social institutions as illustrations for understanding the features of covert social constructions. For example, Sally Haslanger writes:

Consider a landlord. One is a landlord by virtue of one's role in a broad system of social and economic relations which includes tenants, property, and the like. Even if it turned out as a matter of fact that all and only landlords had a closed loop in the center of their right thumbprint, the basis for being counted a landlord is different from the basis for being counted as having such a thumbprint. Likewise for gender, one is a woman, not by virtue of one's intrinsic features (for example, body type), but by virtue of one's part in a system of social relations which includes, among other things, men. Gender is a relational or extrinsic property of individuals, and the relations in question are social.

(2012, 42–43)

Haslanger draws a useful analogy between an overt, institutional role like “landlord” and the sort of covert social role hypothesized by the constructionist, appealing to conceptually structured relations among people to explain the reality of each.

But how far can we take this analogy? Can we understand covert constructions as the *same kind of thing* as overt constructions? The fruitful analogy between them makes this tempting. And this temptation to treat them as alike is further aided by two background trends. First, a long tradition of social philosophical work intimates the possibility that conventional or institutional facts become *reified* or *naturalized*, in a process in which their institutional or social origin comes to be no longer widely understood. Second, recent decades have brought considerable progress in philosophical social ontology, that is, in the offering of explicit accounts of the nature of such entities as social institutions, conventions, and group mental states. Here, as elsewhere in philosophy, it is tempting to understand what is poorly understood by appeal to what is better understood.

Reification

One old, Marxist strand of social scientific thought understands apparently natural facts as the “reified” products of past social arrangements. In *Capital*, Marx writes of “commodity fetishization”:

A commodity is therefore a mysterious thing, simply because in it the social character of men's labour appears to them as an objective character stamped upon the product

of that labour. . . . In the same way the light from an object is perceived by us not as the subjective excitation of our optic nerve, but as the objective form of something outside the eye itself.

(Marx 1967, 77)

Marx's work on commodity fetishization motivates later work by György Lukács (1923) and others on "reification": the process by which facts produced by social arrangements later come to be conceived as existing and having come about independently of those relations. These facts may even be seen as having occasioned those relations. A connection between reification of this sort and covert constructions is not hard to draw. Certain distinctions between superficially different categories might begin as explicit institutions or conventions, but, over time, the differences these conventions produce come to be accepted as natural divisions or the causal consequence of natural divisions that are rooted in intrinsic differences among category members. For instance, a division of labor by sex that begins as a mere convenience ("Let's say that the women will do the A tasks, and the men, the B tasks") comes to be understood as a natural assignment, reflecting organic, sex-specific fitness to the tasks ("Women are just naturally better at the A tasks, and men are naturally fitted to the B tasks").

Similarly, John Searle (1995, 4, 47, 118; cf. Searle 2010) suggests that people may forget, or never even learn, the social character of social facts, mistakenly believing that gold or money is intrinsically valuable, or that some kind of person is naturally suited to rule. He writes:

The complex structure of social reality is, so to speak, weightless and invisible. The child is brought up in a culture where he or she simply takes social reality for granted. We learn to perceive and use cars, bathtubs, houses, money, restaurants, and schools without reflecting on the special features of their ontology and without being aware they have a special ontology. They seem as natural to us as stones and water and trees.
(1995, 4)

According to Searle, such social facts are established by our socio-linguistic activities, but then later *mistaken* for natural facts. More recently, he writes:

There is no general answer to the question of why people accept institutions. Indeed, there are all sorts of institutions where people cheerfully accept what would appear to be unjust arrangements. One thinks of various class structures, the low position of women in many societies, and vastly disproportionate distributions of money, property, and power. But one feature that runs through a large number of cases is that in accepting the institutional facts, people do not typically understand what is going on. They do not think of private property, and the institutions for allocating private property, or human rights, or governments as human creations. They tend to think of them as part of the natural order of things; to be taken for granted in the same way they take for granted the weather or the force of gravity. Sometimes, indeed, they believe institutions to be consequences of a Divine will.

(2010, 107)

Searle here suggests a specific account by which covert construction comes about: explicit, institutional structures are established by social practices, and then later mistaken as features of the natural world – an example of what we called reification above.

How do such mistakes come about? One venerable tradition emphasizes the role of powerful interests in creating an *ideology* that rationalizes these interests. Looked at in this way, failure to preserve or promulgate the correct account of some component of social reality can be part of a plan to conserve or enhance the interests of those who benefit from this arrangement by deceiving the population. It is also possible that such a shift occurs for much more mundane reasons – not because of an intention to mislead, but because of a failure to be concerned with the truth, perhaps assisted by an implicit deference to existing states of affairs or power structures and perhaps aided by psychological biases like folk essentialism (Gelman 2003) or the “fundamental attribution error” in which behavior is explained by appeal to intrinsic features of individuals rather than features of their situation (Ross and Nisbett 1991). Call such a shift from the knowing creation of institutions to ignorance “collective forgetting”.

Whatever its source or cause, such collective forgetting suggests the possibility that covert constructions are essentially just overt constructions – they are, for instance, simply human institutions that we have ceased to recognize as such. This is Searle’s view. Crucially, on Searle’s rendering, reification *does not change the institutional character of what is reified*. If he is right, then to understand the nature of covert constructions, we need simply to understand the nature of institutions and other aspects of overtly constructed social reality.

Social ontology: institutions and conventions

Searle’s own account of institutional facts has it that such facts depend upon the collective *imposition of function* on some thing or things that occurs when there is collective acceptance of a statement of the form:

X counts as Y in C.³

For Searle, “X” is a specification of the individual or type to which the status function applies. For instance, it might specify that tokens of a certain type produced by the U.S. mint count as money in the United States. As Searle emphasizes, status functions of this type go beyond what the intrinsic features of X can secure according to natural laws. There is nothing about the intrinsic features of the tokens that we use as money that gives them the values that they are assigned. Indeed, we can assign the same value to vastly (intrinsically) different tokens: paper, coins, or digital data structures. Their value obtains in virtue of collective acceptance of one or more status functions. “C” specifies the context in which this imposition occurs.⁴

According to Searle, collective acceptance reflects a “collective intentionality”, a feature of human cooperative practices. And, according to Searle, the status functions it imposes carry social obligations – “deontic powers” – that also explain their success as devices for social organization.

As Searle understands them, these collective intentions are a sort of distinctive propositional attitude, “we-intentions” (1990, 1995, 23–26; 2010, 43ff). For example, they might come about when a group decides that “we intend that paper marked as such from the U.S. mint count as money in the United States.” According to Searle, they are irreducible to the “I-intentions” that may be present in the mind of members of a population, indicating an understanding by those individuals of the collective character of the undertaking.⁵

Searle contrasts his account with other accounts of social reality that make no use of “we-intentions”. For instance, a different prominent account of some important features of social reality is found in David Lewis’s (1969) account of conventions. On Lewis’s account, a convention is sustained when it is true that, and it is common knowledge that, everyone participates

in a regularity (for example, *driving on the right side of the road*) on condition that everyone else does (1969, 76). Crucial to Lewis's account of convention is that such a conventional conformity is a *Nash equilibrium*, a regularity that no one can unilaterally deviate from and better satisfy her own preferences. Because it is irrational for an individual to unilaterally deviate from the regularity, individual self-interest stabilizes the regularity.

Can we overtly construct covert kinds?

How could we employ Searle's account of institutions or Lewis's account of conventions to understand covert kinds? Returning to the example of race, we might – as Naomi Zack has (1999, 2002) – apply Searle's schema straightforwardly to generate an account of the social construction of a set of racial categories. Zack writes:

Let skin shade of a certain reflective index, or the existence of an ancestor with skin shade of that reflective index be X . In the context of the United States, X could count as “racially black” (or as “racially white” for a different value of X). . . . Any criterion for racial membership that has a physical factual basis could be some X that gets constructed as a Y or racial classification. Thus, it is racial membership that is socially constructed in Searle's sense.

(2002, 108)

It is not hard to imagine applying the schema to other putatively natural categories as well, and when we do so, it nicely explicates the constructionist idea that the differential features of category members are dependent upon our socio-linguistic practices in differentially treating them.

Alternatively, we might try to understand a norm of differential treatment of some group of people as a Lewisian convention. Consider a case where we take members of a group G to have a favored or disfavored status with regard to a kind of activity A . This could be a racial group that is supposed to be good at sports or at math. Or a sex group that is supposed to be bad at fighting or at nurturing. In each of these cases, we could try to understand *our treatment of members of G as preferred for A* as a conventional fact, as adherence to the norm:

Treat G 's as worse at A .

On the condition that others do so. Where a system of such norms existed with regard to a category G , we could explain the apparent reality of G by appeal to the system of Lewisian conventions. If this were the right account, it would explain how our social practices of differential treatment depend upon the rational dispositions of individual actors, given their self-interest and their beliefs about what others will do.

Covert constructions are not institutions or conventions

Unfortunately, this approach does not work. Covert constructions are, by hypothesis, different than overt constructions like Searlean institutions or Lewisian conventions. For covert constructions, but not overt constructions, we treat them differentially *because we mistakenly take them to be naturally different*, and this false story *rationalizes* differential treatment, which stabilizes the thought and behavior that sustains the social role over time. This difference is not merely epistemic, but actually constitutes overt and covert kinds as different kinds of kinds.

Kind identity

What makes two sorts of kinds the same or different? Here I understand the notion of a kind using Richard Boyd's influential idea of a causally homeostatic property cluster kind (1988, 1991, 1999). While natural kinds have traditionally been understood to be characterized by a simple, all-or-nothing essence, Boyd instead suggests that such kinds can be characterized by a "cluster" of typical but not individually necessary properties that co-occur in the world and whose possession is not an all-or-nothing affair for members of the kind. The co-occurrence of such properties in the kind is not an accident, but is the result of some sort of mechanism of causal homeostasis that sustains the co-occurrence of the properties, enabling reference to the kind to be useful in our predictive and explanatory enterprises.

It is a virtue of such an account that it allows us to extend the idea of natural kinds to the complex and varied kinds that we find in the special sciences, and indeed, as Boyd himself has acknowledged, allows extension to kinds that "combine naturalistic and conventional features in quite complex ways" (1991, 140). I have argued elsewhere that we can understand constructed social role kinds in this way (Mallon 2003, 2016). When we do, we get that constructed kinds are individuated, at least in part, by the mechanism of causal homeostasis for the kind. Where these are the same, we can say that the same kind occurs, and where different, different.⁶ Here I assume that a claim of the sort "*A and B are different kinds*" is true whenever A and B have different mechanisms of causal homeostasis. It is difference between such mechanisms that distinguishes overt and covert socially constructed social roles.

Covert constructions are different: the epistemic argument

We can begin to see that covert constructions are different than overt constructions by considering the epistemic distinctiveness of overt constructions.

Edouard Machery (2014) has argued that reified social facts cannot be Searlean impositions of function because the ignorance that everyone (including Searle) suggests accompanies reification is incompatible with the knowledge required by the collective imposition of function.

[People] tend to think of races as natural, biological kinds, and they often adopt an essentialist attitude toward them. But if people think that races are natural, biological kinds, they cannot collectively recognize, in the relevant sense, the social status of races nor their attendant social roles.

(Machery 2014, 93)

These arguments bring out the contradiction in treating covert constructions as institutions: a thing cannot be simultaneously widely believed to be natural and widely believed to be a product of a collectively imposed convention or status function.

But Machery's argument makes an assumption that Searle seems to reject, the assumption that the operation of status functions requires collective recognition. Searle writes,

The acceptance of an institutional fact, or indeed, of a whole system of status functions, may be based on false beliefs. From the point of institutional analysis, it does not matter whether the beliefs are true or false. It only matters whether the people do in fact collectively recognize or accept the system of status functions.

(2010, 119)

Searle is correct that his account makes no assumption about the nature of the *justification* or *reasons* for engaging in the imposition of a status function. Consider:

G. We intend that persons with properties $p_1, p_2, \dots p_n$ count as members of race r_1 in C.

The reasons for G could advert to social structure, history, magic, nature, or whatever you like, and it makes no difference to his institutional account. However, it is Searle's account of the propositional attitude G itself that runs afoul of the epistemic argument. Someone who genuinely believes in natural races does not participate in a collective intention like G. Rather, she has a different, simpler propositional attitude:

H. I believe that persons with properties $p_1, p_2, \dots p_n$ are members of race r_1 .

False beliefs about naturalness are not Searlean impositions of functions. Thus, Machery replies to Searle:

Searle's response only seems plausible because of an equivocation. If recognizing that some entity x has some property P just means judging that x has P, then, no doubt, people can recognize that reified social entities have a social status and an attendant function. In that sense, people can recognize, indeed collectively recognize, that water is constituted of H_2O . But, if collective recognition is to be understood on the model of a declaration, then it makes little sense to recognize facts that we believe are natural phenomena. As noted above, we do not recognize, in that sense, that water is H_2O . Because declarations are, for Searle, the basis of the mode of existence of social entities, reification is a genuine problem for his account of social ontology.

(2014, 98)

It *does* look as if the idea at the core of Searle's account of social institutions, the idea of acts that collectively impose status functions, acts that he comes to say have "the same logical form as declarations" (2010, 13), requires collective recognition of the social nature of the fact. Thus, Machery is correct that Searle cannot simultaneously allow for reification and for understanding such reified kinds as institutions, in his sense.⁷

However, this passage and others from Searle suggest another possibility that Machery does not consider, one connected to what we called collective forgetting. What if reification occurs in a transition from an explicitly imposed status function to a mistakenly imposed status function? Let an event E at time t collectively impose a status function in Searlean fashion:

We intend that X's count as Y's in C.

On Searle's view, E can be itself a declaration, or simply "have the logical form" of a declaration. Machery's point is that E entails collective recognition that the created fact is a social fact and this is inconsistent with X's counting as Y being understood as a natural fact.

But if E creates a social institution, that fact may not be recognized at a later time, a time after t . Suppose at this later time, people forget (or fail to learn) about E and come to believe that

X's are Y's is a natural fact.

This collective forgetting model of reification seems to allow Searle to have his collective recognition (at t) and deny it too (later on). Anyone who wants to argue (like Machery and I) that covert constructions cannot be understood as reified Searlean institutions needs an argument for why these reified facts do not continue to be institutional facts even after their mode of creation is forgotten. In the next section, I offer such an argument.

I have been framing this discussion in terms of Searle's account of institutions that makes use of the idea of we-intentions. However, we can see related phenomena on other accounts of social reality. Consider again Lewis's account of conventions. For Lewis, individual behavior according to a conventional regularity is conditional upon each individual understanding of what others will do given common knowledge of the situation and regularity. Conventions amount to conformity with regularities that are Nash equilibria, where no one can unilaterally deviate from the regularity and do better. Notice that this cognitive state – the state of believing one's action is the best conditional upon the belief that others also recognize that their actions are the best – is *not* the mental state that obtains of participants in a covert construction. Rather, when one takes something to have its properties as a result of some natural, intrinsic property, one treats it as having those properties *independently* of how oneself and others regard it. In such cases, one's actions in conformity with a regularity are conditional upon beliefs about the human-independent features of the kind, not conditional upon the dispositions or actions of others.

Different kinds of kinds: the ontological argument

Covert constructionists hold that putatively natural kinds are in fact produced by our socio-linguistic activities. It follows from this general view:

- 1 Terms for covert constructions are widely believed to pick out natural kinds.
- 2 Terms for covert constructions actually pick out some sort of socially produced kind.

What we have been asking is if understanding the socially produced kind in 2 as a Searlean institution or Lewisian convention is consistent with the truth of 1. In this sub-section, I argue that it is not; "reification" makes a social role a different kind of kind.

What sort of kind is a Searlean institution? Take a simple example. Four friends find that they all enjoy singing a cappella. They decide to declare themselves a barbershop quartet: the Windy Wendells. They democratically elect a leader, Director of the Windy Wendells. Before taking the vote, the quartet members have the intentional state:

We intend that whoever gets the most votes in our secret ballot counts as the Director of the Windy Wendells for two years.

They hold an election, and Reed wins. They then have the mental state that:

We intend that Reed counts as the Director of the Windy Wendells for two years.

Furthermore, they agree:

We intend that the Director of the Windy Wendells shall set the concert schedule and the song list for each concert.

The term “Director of the Windy Wendells” picks out a property that Reed has in virtue of the existence of the imposed status function, one that gives him certain other prerogatives.

What gives the kind “Director of the Windy Wendells” its causal power and stability over time? In its simplest formulation, the mechanism of an imposed status function is the set of “we-intentions” that produce and maintain it, mental states that involve reference to oneself and others as a collective. The we-intention works to produce and regulate behaviors by and towards members of a kind because we-intentions carry with them what Searle calls “deontic powers” that work upon *prima facie* dispositions to cooperate with others in sustaining the institution. The mental dispositions of people to remember imposed status functions and respect their deontic force stabilize institutional kinds, giving them their causal power.

This is not true for covert constructions. Even if an entity begins as a Searlean institution, reification suggests that cooperative we-intentions no longer obtain. Reification involves a situation in which status functions are no longer remembered as such, and so they do not have deontic power. In such cases, *X’s are Y’s* is not seen as a result of cooperation or collective intentionality. It is rather believed to be the result of natural facts about X’s. It follows that covert constructions lack the mechanism that lies at the heart of overt, Searlean institutions: the existence of we-intentions and the attendant dispositions to cooperate.

What holds covert constructions together, then? Covert constructions *contrast* with overt constructions in that covert constructions *are stabilized by the mistaken belief in their naturalness*. The idea that a kind can be stabilized by mistaken belief in its naturalness is very old in philosophy. Famously, Plato in *The Republic* advocates stabilizing the social order of the Republic by spreading a “noble lie”:

we will say in our tale, yet God in fashioning those of you who are fitted to hold rule mingled gold in their generation, for which reason they are the most precious – but in the helpers silver, and iron and brass in the farmers and other craftsmen.

(1961, 415a-b)

The different social roles of the Republic are stabilized not only by institution or by convention, but also by belief in underlying facts about the natures of each of the social classes. On this interpretation, the constructionist view rests on the idea, exploited by Plato, that belief in the naturalness of a category is a mechanism that can stabilize a kind. Searle himself realizes the possibility that, “In the extreme case an institutional fact might function only because it is not believed to be an institutional fact” (2010, 119). But he fails to acknowledge that such a fact would no longer be institutional in his sense, because the kind it makes reference to is not sustained by we-intentions, deontic powers, or cooperative dispositions. Because the mechanism of causal homeostasis is different, the kind is different.

We can illustrate these differences between overt and covert constructions by considering the differing counterfactuals that emerge between overt and covert constructionist views (Mallon in press). Consider a role like “traffic officer”. For Searle, roughly, what makes the traffic officer a traffic officer, and gives her the right to direct traffic and issue traffic citations, is the collective imposition of these functions upon her by a community. Counterfactually, if everyone stopped imposing these functions, then there would be no status function and no obligation to obey the officer. For each individual, there would no longer be a disposition to continuing to act as if the traffic cop could give orders or issue citations.

And the point, again, extends to other accounts of social reality. Lewisian conventions depend upon strategic choices by individuals, behavior that is contingent upon the rational preferences

of others. Consider the norm “stop when the traffic officer indicates to do so.” If this norm were sustained by a Lewisian convention, each person’s participation in the regularity would depend upon that person’s beliefs about what others will do, prefer, and so forth. If no one else participated in the convention, that would undermine one’s own reasons for participating in it.

In contrast, in the covertly constructed social role case of the sort we have been considering, behavior is sustained by beliefs in the natural features of the world. Consider a community *c* in which men and women are equally able to perform a job type J, but that for various historical reasons women are more prevalent at job type J. Suppose, moreover, that, in *c*, it is widely believed that

Q. Women are better at job type J because of their biology.

Suppose Sarah is an employer seeking to fill a job of type J. If Sarah, as others in *c*, believes Q, then Sarah might rationally prefer women candidates for the job because of their putative superiority at that type of work. This preference is not conditional upon everyone else endorsing a status function nor is it conditional upon a desire to behave in accord with a regularity, given that everyone else does. It is not even conditional upon others believing Q; if everyone else believed that men were naturally better at J, Sarah might still rationally prefer to hire women because of her belief in Q. This sort of illustration makes clear that covert constructions are stabilized and explained by different facts than those that stabilize and explain overt constructions. This is a reflection of the different mechanisms that stabilize overt and covert kinds – a reflection of the fact that they are different kinds of kinds.

Generalizing, if one treats men or women or members of different races *as* having some functions in virtue of a we-intention or convention, then that treatment is the result of mental states that are conditional upon the psychological and behavioral dispositions of others. But if one treats men or women or members of different races as different in virtue of natural facts, then that treatment is the result of mental states that are not conditional upon beliefs about others but rather conditional upon beliefs about the natural features of the world.

This discussion has been narrowly focused upon the character of socially constructed human categories, arguing that there are at least two kinds of kinds that secure the stability of human kinds: one centered on attitudes involving others (for Searle, collective acceptance; for Lewis, common knowledge of a Nash equilibrium), and one centered upon mistaken naturalness. But other recent work on social reality makes it tempting, and ultimately, I think correct, to draw the more general conclusion that there are, as Brian Epstein has put it, “many kinds of social glue” that hold the social world together (Epstein 2014). These may include something like “collective intentions” of the sort that figures in work by Searle and others, the sort of game-theoretic equilibria that Lewis’s account of convention emphasizes (cf. Mallon 2003), as well as mistakes about what is natural that figure in constructionist work. Once we see this, we might then add a range of other mechanisms that may play a role in stabilizing human categories and add to their causal power (Mallon 2003; Mallon and Kelly 2012; Guala and Hindriks 2015). If this is right, the argument I have given is a simply a piece in a larger shift towards recognition of many mechanisms that produce social reality.

Reification and social change

The claim that covert constructions are not the same kind of kind as overt constructions is consistent with the view that covert constructions began as institutions or conventions, sustained by collective recognition or individual appreciation of a solution to a coordination problem.

Practices that were initially adhered to out of collective recognition might eventually have come to be understood as natural facts. Because of the gradual turnover in population, such a transition may be described, as I have, as a sort of collective forgetting. The present argument is that as:

We intend that X's count as Y's in C.

gives way to the simple:

X's are Y's.

the character of the kind picked out by X undergoes an "alchemical" transformation: it becomes a different kind because the mechanism that sustains it changes.

Recognition of multiple representational mechanisms that sustain social reality also suggests a broader conclusion about critical practices: where human intentional processes produce or stabilize the social world, transforming the social world via reasoned argument requires addressing the precise content of the intentions that produce and sustain it. Where overt construction occurs, this involves explicit attention to the character of the status functions or conventions that are in play, and what alternatives might take their place. But where covert construction is in play, social transformation requires addressing and refuting false beliefs about the mechanisms that produce the social world.

Many obstacles face such attempts at social transformation. Such false beliefs may themselves be supported epistemically by the causal order the constructive processes have created. Powerful interests who benefit from existing arrangements may also stabilize them.⁸ And they may be stabilized by psychological biases that create cognitive illusions of plausibility around mistaken explanations.

Thus conceived, we can see the project of many covert social constructionists as the attempt to, in effect, overcome these obstacles and reverse reification. Covert constructionists hope that when we see that our practices are sustained by mistakes about the nature of human kinds, the continuation of these practices will become a matter of collective choice or coordination, opening the possibility of better choices or arrangements.

Notes

- 1 I am grateful to Frank Hindriks and Julian Kiverstein for helpful criticism of an earlier version of this paper.
- 2 Cf. Mallon (2016), ch. 2 for more discussion.
- 3 Later, Searle (2010) suggests several alternate renderings of the imposition of function.
- 4 Searle is just one prominent examples of a thriving literature on social ontology (see also, e.g., Tuomela 2013; Gilbert 1989).
- 5 More recently, Searle (2010) offers a number of emendations to his basic account, including acknowledging "though 'X counts as Y in C' is one form of Status Function Declaration, there are also other forms" (19). Still, he maintains: "all of human institutional reality is created and maintained in existence by (representations that have the same logical form as) [Status Function] Declarations" (13).
- 6 Craver (2009), Khalidi (2013), and Slater (2015) all suggest that individuating mechanisms are not necessary for kinds. Here I assume only that distinct mechanisms are a sufficient reason for a fine-grained individuation of kinds.
- 7 Amy Thomasson (2003) similarly suggests that Searlean institutions produce a kind of first person authority with regard to the nature of the institution. Such authority looks to be inconsistent with the kind of error that reification seems to involve.
- 8 See, e.g., Petrović (1983). Some elaborations of Marx's idea emphasize the connection of reification to capital. Honneth (2008) offers further social theoretic discussion of reification.

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